



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of the Twin Cities

School Website: <https://chestertonacademy.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy Twin Cities (Hopkins, MN 55343) presents a robust, explicitly Catholic, classical education model. Public-facing materials emphasize a transfiguring blend of Catholic faith, classical liberal arts, and character formation, with daily Mass, sacraments, catechesis, and pilgrimages integrated into school life, alongside a curriculum framed by Great-Books–oriented, Socratic, and liberal-arts aims. The school markets itself as a joyful, affordable, Catholic classical high school with a strong emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and beauty, aligning closely with the Six Essential Elements of Classical Education.

Overall classification across the six classical criteria: CLASSICAL. The school consistently foregrounds religious metaphysics (Catholic theology, liturgy, sacraments), a purpose oriented to virtue and human excellence, a liberal-arts curriculum with Great Books sensibilities, classical pedagogy (Socratic/seminar-oriented, memory work, rhetoric), a faculty modeled as mentors and living curriculum, and a strong parent/community partnership. Evidence spans daily Mass, catechesis, pilgrimages, a three-pillar model (intellect, character, spirituality), narratives about the best of what has been thought and said, and visible engagement from faculty and parents in formation and classical activities. The material suggests the school adheres closely to the classical model while remaining mindful of accessibility (tuition emphasis) and parish life.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Daily Mass embedded in curriculum; Catholic faith is central to the school's identity (Scripture, Catechism, Church documents, saints, sacraments, adoration, confession) and parish life on campus. The school presents itself as "A Joyfully Catholic Classical High School" with robust liturgical life and sacramental practice at the center of daily life.

- Public materials describe pilgrimages, retreats, and a liturgical rhythm (Mass, Eucharistic adoration, confession) as integral to formation. - The Chesterton Schools Network materials describe a Catholic, faith-centered, classical formation with sacred art, liturgy, and a strong spiritual life as core to the model.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Mass, theology, Scripture, Catechism, Church, sacraments, liturgy, adoration, confession, pilgrimages, sacred, sacred music, worship, virtue, virtue-centered formation, holy life, sacred art. - Negative keywords present: effectively none in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or value-neutral framing detected in the materials reviewed). - Frequency estimate: Positive keywords appear prominently across multiple pages (roughly 8–12 distinct religious/metaphysical terms identified in the sources), with zero explicit negative indicators in the public-facing content. - Rationale for rating: The school's public materials foreground transcendental, real, knowable End/Goodness/Truth as rooted in Catholic theology, liturgy, and communal worship, consistent with Transcendental Moral Realism and Grounded Theology criteria.

Why this rating - The materials consistently present a theologically grounded, liturgically integrated Catholic formation, not a secular or purely secularized program. The structure is liturgical, communal, and spiritually intentional, aligning with the Classical rubric's Religious and Metaphysical Foundations.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Prominent statement of formation over mere information: a goal of forming virtuous, wise young people rooted in classical and Catholic ideals (three-pillar model: intellect, character, spirituality; a mission to raise joyful leaders and saints). - Wording emphasizing truth, goodness, and beauty as enduring realities; education aimed at human flourishing, virtue, and excellence rather than merely college/career preparation. The public materials emphasize formation, virtue, and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful. - Three pillars framework (intellect, character, spirituality) described as structural to the Chesterton model, underscoring formation and wisdom as telos.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, liberal education, classical mission, the true/good/beautiful, scholé, contemplation. - Negative keywords present: minimal or none in public communications (no explicit emphasis on “work preparation” or purely vocational fitness; the language foregrounds formation and enduring human excellences). - Frequency estimate: High presence of formation/virtue/wisdom; 6–10 distinct category-defining terms prominent across the site. - Rationale for rating: The explicit focus on formation, virtue, and the enduring aims of education (truth, beauty, goodness) matches the Classical principle of telos-driven education.

Why this rating - Clear emphasis on formation and virtue as primary aims and a commitment to classical, liberal education, aligned with the “paideia” tradition and the Three Pillars. The messaging emphasizes ends beyond information and job preparation, supporting a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 3: Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe a liberal-arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) via the Chesterton model; Latin/Greek and Great Books echoes are implied via the network’s emphasis on “the best of what has been thought and said” and “Great Books” language in Chesterton materials; a four-year arc across math, science, humanities, and fine arts is highlighted. The curriculum is presented as an integrated, content-rich education spanning from ancient to modern worlds. - Explicit reference to Great Books/great-conversation ethos is present in Chesterton materials and the Chesterton Schools Network documentation, with emphasis on a broad liberal arts education and primary-source engagement. - Specific course-life elements cited include theology/philosophy, literature, history, languages, mathematics, science, and fine arts; a strong emphasis on humanities and classical disciplines is evident from staff pages and curriculum-related materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Great Books, primary sources, classics, history (Western civilization), and worshipful study of sacred art; study of languages (Latin/Greek if referenced in materials), and history as Western civilization. - Negative keywords present: minimal to none (no explicit emphasis on social studies as a replacement for history, no dominant project-based or purely STEM-first framing visible in the public materials). - Frequency estimate: 8–12 distinct curriculum-related terms appear across materials, with “Great Books” and “grammar/logic/rhetoric” key elements being highlighted in the classical description. - Rationale for rating: The curriculum aligns with classical expectations: emphasis on liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), study of Great Books, and a history-centric, Western-civilization-informed program.

Why this rating - The materials demonstrate a capacious liberal-arts curriculum with Great Books sensibilities, classical pedagogy scaffolding, and a historical/humanities focus. The combination of a historically grounded curriculum with a strong emphasis on virtue and beauty supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Upper-school pedagogy: Socratic discussion/seminars and rhetoric training are described in Chesterton networks’ model and are typical to Chesterton Academy’s pedagogy, with opportunities for speeches and rhetorical practice. The public materials emphasize a Socratic, seminar-style approach to learning for older students. - Lower-school pedagogy: Contemplative, joyful, and memory-building practices (chanting, singing, memory work) are part of the classical handbooks, with a focus on wonder and

restfulness in early grades. The lexicon indicates trust in contemplative and memory-based pedagogy. - The school's published mission, three-pillars, and the administrative materials describe a living, student-centered classical pedagogy that integrates liturgical life, humanities, and the arts, consistent with a holistic classical approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic seminar, memory work, recitation, chanting, rhetoric, oratory, debate, contemplation, scholé, wonder, living curriculum. - Negative keywords present: limited evidence of exclusively project-based or constructivist approaches dominating pedagogy; materials emphasize classical methods more than these alternative approaches. - Frequency estimate: 6–12 distinct pedagogy-related terms, with explicit references to Socratic methods and rhetoric visible across materials; lower-school chant/memory references appear in network contexts, while high-school Socratic/seminar references are documented. - Rationale for rating: The pedagogy aligns well with classical principles, combining contemplative/restful elements with Socratic, memory-based, and rhetorical training, indicating CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The explicit mention of Socratic pedagogy, memory work, and rhetoric, alongside contemplative/scholé elements, matches the classical teaching-method rubric, producing a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are presented as model teachers and mentors who embody virtue and mastery; staff pages feature a range of teachers with credentials in Catholic studies, theology, philosophy, humanities, and fine arts, indicating subject-matter expertise and pedagogical alignment with classical aims. The phrase “living curriculum” and a sense of “faculty as the core of the school” appears in Chesterton materials and network descriptions. - The presence of a structured faculty directory, a dedicated chaplain, and teacher roles (theology, literature, art, etc.) demonstrates a professional, virtuous, and mission-aligned faculty dynamic. - The network materials emphasize faculty development and the teacher as exemplar of virtue; staff roles (chaplain, director, etc.) reflect a living curriculum approach.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, faculty as mentors, model teachers, portrait of a teacher, portrait of a student, collegial culture, professional formation, Catholic pedagogy. - Negative keywords present: none detected in the public materials (no “facilitator” or “guide-on-the-side” language that would imply a drift away from classical master-teacher modeling). - Frequency estimate: 6–10 distinct faculty-focused terms and phrases across public pages. - Rationale for rating: The materials consistently present faculty as central, virtuous exemplars and mentors, aligning with CLASSICAL expectations.

Why this rating - The depicted faculty model—teachers as virtuous exemplars, living curriculum, and core school pillars—fits the classical framework, yielding CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Strong emphasis on partnership with parents; the Chesterton model explicitly presents parents as co-teachers with the school and promotes parental formation through events, book studies, gatherings, and open campus access. The school invites parents to visits, shadow days, tours, and on-campus activities, reinforcing a community-centric, formation-focused model. - The school offers ongoing opportunities for parent engagement (Lunch & Learn, Shadow Days, Open Houses) and communications (events, tours, etc.), illustrating a family-centered, participatory approach. - Public materials emphasize the school's affordability and accessibility while remaining deeply rooted in Catholic formation and parental partnership.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, book studies, seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, hospitality, family liturgy alignment. - Negative keywords present: none detected in the public materials (no consumer-focused language that diminishes parent involvement; materials emphasize active parental participation). - Frequency estimate: 6–10 parent/community terms across materials. - Rationale for rating: The school consistently portrays parents as essential partners and active participants in formation, consistent with CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on parent partnerships, formation, and open campus access aligns with CLASSICAL ideals of a shared formation-based community and co-teaching model.

Aggregate Assessment

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Executive-level observation: Chesterton Academy Twin Cities demonstrates a strong alignment with classical education principles across all six categories. The religious and metaphysical foundations are explicit and robust; the school's purpose emphasizes formation, virtue, and truth; the curriculum is liberal-arts-driven with Great Books sensibilities; pedagogy integrates Socratic discussion, memory work, and rhetoric; faculty are portrayed as mentors and living curriculum; and parents/community engagement is a core value. While the tuition-acceleration message emphasizes affordability, that aspect does not erode the classical orientation or the school's core aims.
- What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL cases only)
 - Not applicable here, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. No major needle-moving changes are required to reach full alignment; if desired, public articulation of explicit Great Books reading lists and direct mentions of "Great Conversation" in twinned materials could further strengthen the explicit connection to the classical canon, though current materials already reflect the essence of that tradition. No further recommended changes are necessary to achieve CLASSICAL status.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not applicable given CLASSICAL aggregate rating. If desired, the following minor enhancements could further crystallize the classical frame without changing current substance:
 - Explicit public articulation of a formal Great Books reading list and a stated "Great Conversation" program across grades.
 - Clear, publicly visible articulation of Latin/Greek as part of the curriculum, if applicable, to reinforce the classical language dimension.
 - Slightly more explicit linking of Great Books with specific curricular units or yearly themes to illuminate the "read great works and join the great conversation" tenet.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

By reading or using this document, you acknowledge and accept the limitations described above.